

Lesson 40: Finding Joy in Temple and Family History Work (See L40 [Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help us see the many different ways we can participate in temple and family history work and to encourage us to prayerfully determine the ways we should participate now.

1. The Spirit of Elijah is prompting people to turn their hearts to their ancestors.

The Spirit of Elijah “refers to the desire people have to ‘turn the hearts of the fathers to the children, and the children to the fathers’ (D&C 110:15). We call it the Spirit of Elijah because Elijah restored the keys of the sealing power of the priesthood to Joseph Smith (D&C 110:13-16). Through this power, sealing ordinances can be performed that unite families for eternity. (*Lesson Manual*)

What does the Spirit of Elijah influence members of the Church to do?

What experiences have you had when you have felt influenced by the Spirit of Elijah?

†1. President Gordon B. Hinckley

What are some things that the Spirit of Elijah is guiding people to do throughout the world?

2. Each member of the Church can participate in temple and family history work.

Tell about some experiences you had with temple and family history work this past week.

†2. President Boyd K. Packer

How has temple and family history work helped you feel increased spiritual refinement and power?

†3. Elder Dallin H. Oaks

What are some things you have done to participate in temple and family history work?

One “thing we can do to participate in temple and family history work is have a current temple recommend and attend the temple as often as circumstances allow.” (*Lesson Manual*) †4. President Gordon B. Hinckley

Even “if our circumstances do not allow us to attend regularly, we should hold a temple recommend.” (*LM*)

†5. President Howard W. Hunter

1. Have a current temple recommend and attend the temple regularly:

What blessings can we receive through holding a temple recommend and attending the temple?

How can parents teach their children about the importance of the temple?

2. Prepare to have ordinances performed for deceased relatives: “Even if others in our families have worked on family history, we can often find deceased relatives who still need to have temple ordinances performed for them.” (*Lesson Manual*) †6. Ways to find our ancestors †7. Elder Richard G. Scott

3. Learn about ancestors’ lives:

How have you learned about your ancestors’ lives? How has remembering them blessed you?

What can parents do to teach their children about their ancestors?

†8. Elder Dennis B. Neuenschwander

4. Keep a journal or prepare a personal history or family history: †9. President Spencer W. Kimball

How does keeping a journal or a personal history help us participate in family history?

What are the blessings of keeping a journal or preparing a history?

How are we personally blessed and how are our descendants blessed?

How can preparing a family history help turn our hearts to our family members?

3. The Church provides many resources to help us participate in temple and family history work.

The “Church provides many resources to help us participate in temple and family history work. These include:

- [A Member’s Guide to Temple and Family History Work](#) (34697)
- Family history forms (such as pedigree charts and family group records).
- Computer programs.
- Information on the Internet.
- [Family History Centers](#)
- [Family Search](#) at lds.org. Find the link in the left-hand column in the last group of links at the bottom.
- [Family History](#) at lds.org. Find the link in “Resources” in the far left “Family” column.” (*Lesson Manual*)

Next Week: L41: “Every Member a Missionary”; See L41 [Class Member Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).) † •

†1. **President Gordon B. Hinckley:** “All of our vast family history endeavor is directed to temple work. There is no other purpose for it. The temple ordinances become the crowning blessings the Church has to offer” (“[New Temples to Provide ‘Crowning Blessings’ of the Gospel](#),” *Ensign*, May 1998, 88).

†2. **President Boyd K. Packer:** “No work is more of a protection to this church than temple work and the genealogical research that supports it. No work is more spiritually refining. No work we do gives us more power” (“[The Holy Temple](#),” *Ensign*, Feb. 1995, 36).

†3. **Elder Dallin H. Oaks:** “In the work of redeeming the dead there are many tasks to be performed, and ... all members should participate by prayerfully selecting those ways that fit their personal circumstances at a particular time. ... Our effort is not to compel everyone to do everything, but to encourage everyone to do something” (“[Family History: ‘In Wisdom and Order](#),”” *Ensign*, June 1989, 6).

†4. **President Gordon B. Hinckley:** “I urge our people everywhere, with all of the persuasiveness of which I am capable, to live worthy to hold a temple recommend, to secure one and regard it as a precious asset, and to make a greater effort to go to the house of the Lord and partake of the spirit and the blessings to be had therein. I am satisfied that every man or woman who goes to the temple in a spirit of sincerity and faith leaves the house of the Lord a better man or woman. There is need for constant improvement in all of our lives. There is need occasionally to leave the noise and the tumult of the world and step within the walls of a sacred house of God, there to feel His spirit in an environment of holiness and peace” (“[Of Missions, Temples, and Stewardship](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1995, 53).

†5. **President Howard W. Hunter:** “It would please the Lord if every adult member would be worthy of—and carry—a current temple recommend. The things that we must do and not do to be worthy of a temple recommend are the very things that ensure we will be happy as individuals and as families” (“[Exceeding Great and Precious Promises](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1994, 8).

†6. **Ways to find our ancestors:** “We begin this process by identifying our deceased relatives. We can list those whom we remember, look through family records, and ask parents, grandparents, and other family members to tell us about other ancestors. We can also use Church-produced computer programs in our homes and in Family History Centers to help us in these efforts. Emphasize the powerful influence of the Spirit in helping us identify ancestors. As we exercise faith, names and information may come to us in unexpected ways and places.

“As we learn about our ancestors, we should record the information we find on family history forms, such as pedigree charts and family group records. If an ancestor received any priesthood ordinances before death, it is helpful to record the dates when those ordinances were performed so we can know which ones still need to be done.

Family history consultants in the ward, branch, or stake can help us prepare the information that the temple will need before ordinances may be performed for our ancestors. Church family history publications, local priesthood leaders, and temples should also have these instructions. (*Lesson Manual*)

†7. **Elder Richard G. Scott:** “Arrange to participate for deceased ancestors in the sealing and other ordinances. ... I find it helpful when receiving ordinances for another to try and relate to that person specifically. I think of him and pray that he will accept the ordinance and benefit from it. Do these things with a prayer in your heart that the Holy Spirit will enhance your understanding and enrich your life. Those worthy prayers will be answered” (“[Receive the Temple Blessings](#),” *Ensign*, May 1999, 27).

Recommended reading:

1. Elder Russell M. Nelson, “[The Spirit of Elijah](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1994, 85.
2. Margaret D. Nadauld, “[Turning Hearts to the Family](#),” *Ensign*, May 1998.
3. President Boyd K. Packer, “[The Holy Temple](#),” *Ensign*, Feb. 1995, 36.
4. Elder Dallin H. Oaks, “[Family History: ‘In Wisdom and Order](#),”” *Ensign*, June 1989, 6.
5. Elder Dennis B. Neuenschwander, “[Bridges and Eternal Keepsakes](#),” *Ensign*, May 1999, 83–84.

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†8. Elder Dennis B. Neuenschwander: “Not one of my children has any recollection of my grandparents. If I want my children and grandchildren to know those who still live in my memory, then I must build the bridge between them. I alone am the link to the generations that stand on either side of me. It is my responsibility to knit their hearts together through love and respect, even though they may never have known each other personally. My grandchildren will have no knowledge of their family’s history if I do nothing to preserve it for them. That which I do not in some way record will be lost at my death, and that which I do not pass on to my posterity, they will never have. The work of gathering and sharing eternal family keepsakes is a personal responsibility. It cannot be passed off or given to another” (“[Bridges and Eternal Keepsakes](#),” *Ensign*, May 1999, 83–84).

†9. President Spencer W. Kimball: “On a number of occasions I have encouraged the Saints to keep personal journals and family records. I renew that admonition. We may think there is little of interest or importance in what we personally say or do, but it is remarkable how many of our families, as we pass on down the line, are interested in all that we do and all that we say.

Any Latter-day Saint family that has searched genealogical and historical records has fervently wished its ancestors had kept better and more complete records. On the other hand, some families possess some spiritual treasures because ancestors have recorded the events surrounding their conversion to the gospel and other happenings of interest, including many miraculous blessings and spiritual experiences.” (*President Kimball Speaks Out*, 54)

Recommended media:

1. Video: [It’s About the Dash](#) (2:57)
2. Video: [Now I’m Converted](#) (4:22)
3. Video: [He Was a Blacksmith](#) (2:12)
4. Image: [Elijah Restoring the Power to Seal Families for Eternity](#)
5. Website: <https://familysearch.org/>

Further recommended reading:

1. President J. Grant, “[Comforting Manifestations](#),” *Improvement Era*, Feb. 1931, 189–190. (Read about Feramorz L. Young who died on his mission to Mexico and appeared in a dream to Horace G. Whitney, a close friend of President Grant’s. Note what he tells Horace. Also read the story about the beautiful young woman who came to his mother in a dream.)
2. [Nancy Jensen](#), at Gospel Doctrine Plus, in Lesson #40.
3. George S. Tate, “[I Saw the Hosts of the Dead](#),” *Ensign*, Dec. 2009, pp. 54–59.
4. Stephen D. Ricks, “[The Appearance of Elijah and Moses in the Kirtland Temple and the Jewish Passover](#),” *BYU Studies Quarterly*, 23:4.
5. Masakazu Watabe, “[Elijah’s Promise: An Oriental View](#),” *BYU Studies*.
6. James B. Allen, et. al., “[Prologue: The Spirit of Elijah](#),” *BYU Studies*.

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